

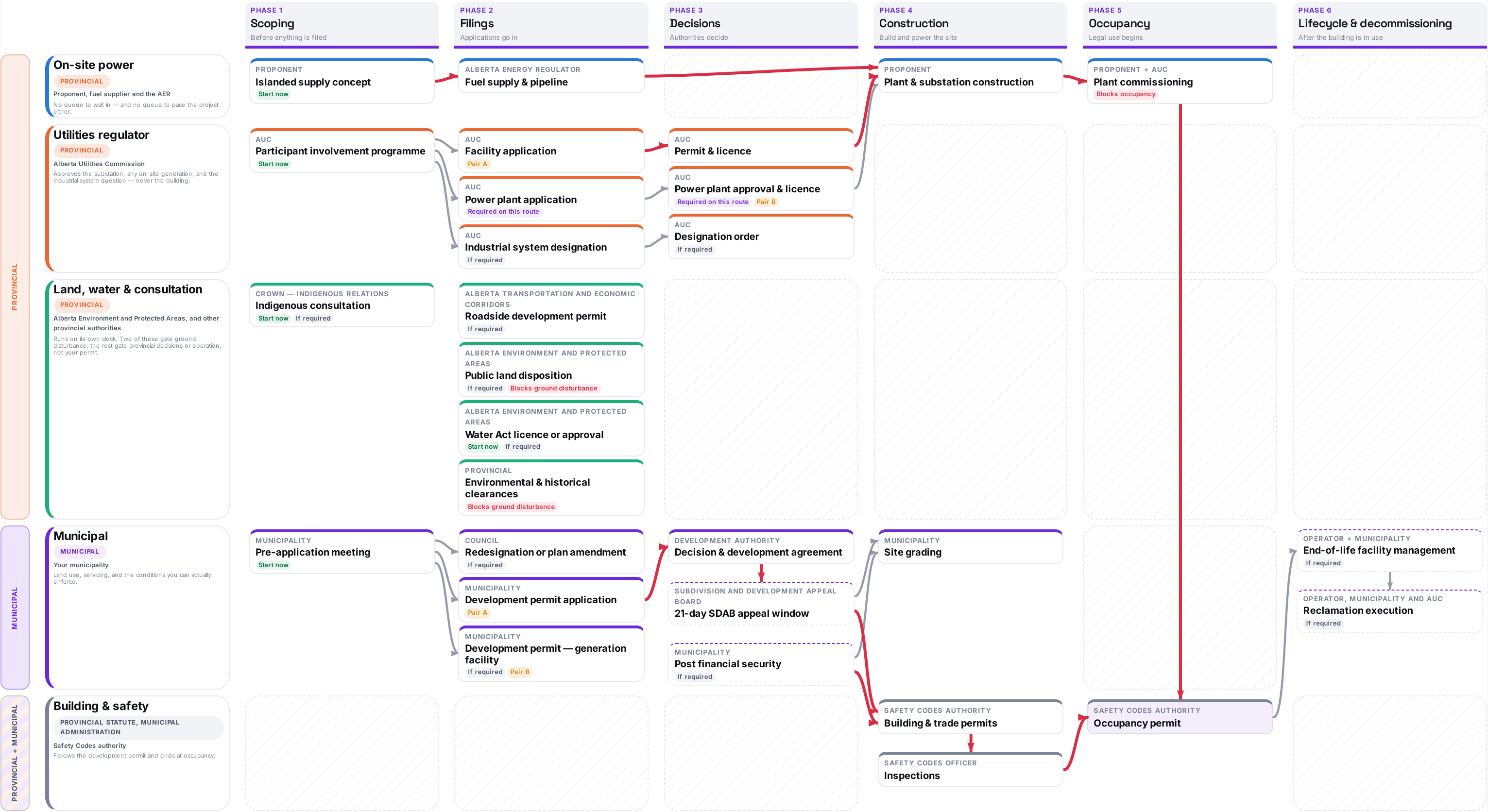
From first enquiry to occupancy

The same site with no connection to the AESO system: generation on site feeds the substation, and the substation feeds the load. The whole grid lane falls away and the AESO steps with it. Nothing municipal falls away — and because the connection queue is no longer setting the pace, the municipal decision can become the earliest binding date on the file.

Load served entirely by generation on the site. No system access service, no transmission connection, no queue.

Critical path — delay here moves the finish date    Arrow: must finish before    Same column: same stage, no order implied between them    A The same letter on two cards: one thing, two applications — both required, neither authorises the other

Start now    Independent of everything else — begin in week one    If required    Only some projects engage this    Required on this route    Conditional on the other route, not this one    Blocks ...    Blocks what it names — that step cannot start until this is done    Lane colour marks which authority decides — it is not a ranking





How to read a pair letter

Two cards carrying the same letter are two separate applications, to two different authorities, for the same physical thing on one site — one pair is the substation, the other the on-site power plant. Both are required, and neither authorises the other: a decision on one does not oblige the other to follow. There is no order between them, which is why they carry a letter rather than an arrow — they can be filed and decided in either sequence, or at the same time. It matters because holding the provincial permit is not holding the municipal one, and a project can win one and lose the other. Check that the site plan filed with each shows the same footprint and that the conditions do not contradict, and reconcile them at pre-application rather than at decision.



A power plant needs both approvals

Where a project proposes on-site generation, the AUC approves the generating facility and the municipality still permits the site development around it. They are separate files on separate records, marked here by a shared pair letter on both cards. Neither one authorises the other.



Two approvals, one site

The municipality approves the building; the AUC approves the substation that powers it. Neither authorises the other, and both site plans must show the same footprint — reconcile them at pre-application, not at decision.



Occupancy is the real gate

Construction can finish while the power is still outstanding — an unfinished connection on the grid route, an uncommissioned plant or an unsecured fuel supply off it. Conditioning occupancy, rather than construction, on evidence of firm power is enforceable, within municipal jurisdiction, and prevents a stranded building.



Off the grid is not off the hook

Taking the AESO out of the picture removes one lane and nothing else. The power plant approval stops being conditional and becomes the project’s licence to operate at all, the industrial system question appears, and every municipal and building approval is exactly as it was. What changes is the timing, not the scope.



The queue was doing you a favour

On the grid route the connection queue paces the project, and a permit decision has years of construction runway behind it. Off-grid there is no queue. The municipal decision can become the earliest binding date on the file, so conditions and the development agreement carry weight they would not otherwise have to.



Test the claim that a site is islanded

Ask three things in writing: is there any standby, backup or import arrangement; is a connection intended in a later phase; and what serves the load when the plant is down. Any of the three can turn an off-grid project back into a grid one. Note also that the province's computing equipment levy is tiered by whether a facility is grid-connected, which gives an applicant a reason to describe a project as off-grid — the levy detail on the rules page is media-reported rather than primary, so read it at source before relying on it.



A different week-one list

Off-grid the four independent starts change: the municipal pre-application, the AUC participant involvement programme for the power plant, the islanded supply concept and the fuel enquiry behind it, and any water licence. The AESO request is not among them — and its absence is exactly why this route can arrive faster than a municipality expects.

A map of the process, not legal advice. Confirm each requirement against the authority named before relying on it.